



MONTHLY UPDATE

East Africa: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-07 • 19 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

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Summary of the month

The EAC's payments masterplan reached implementation this month: three Technical Working Groups met for the first time in Mombasa on 18-22 August, days after the Community's Monetary Affairs Committee had already conceded on 18 August that a separate, older currency-convertibility MoU remains unevenly applied twelve years on. IGAD opened a new cross-border trade knowledge-sharing network on 21 August, and a joint account opened by Uganda, Kenya, Rwanda and South Sudan on 24 August put a public, dated deadline on funding a shared communications satellite feasibility study. EACO's first regulator-submitted communications statistics report, published 3 August, put the region's active mobile subscriptions at 334.69 million while flagging its own currency-conversion figures as unexplained.

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

The EAC Cross-Border Payment System Masterplan moved from a five-year framework with no delivery body to one with three: its first Technical Working Groups met in Mombasa, 18-22 August, chaired by the Bank of Uganda with the National Bank of Rwanda as rapporteur, considering a Monitoring and Reporting Framework aligned to G20 targets, a Regional Cooperative Oversight Framework and a Mutual Recognition Framework for licensed payment providers. Days earlier, at the same committee's 29th ordinary meeting, EAC central bank governors had conceded that the region's separate 2014 currency-convertibility and repatriation MoU remains unevenly implemented, agreeing a technical working group and a sub-committee meeting, both due by December 2026, with the Bank of Tanzania leading.

IGAD member states adopted terms of reference for a Cross-Border Trade Knowledge-Sharing Network at the close of a two-day Nairobi consultation on 21 August, settling its membership, governance and role as a platform for evidence-based cross-border agricultural trade decisions, funded through the World Bank's Food Systems Resilience Programme.

The EAC Council of Ministers approved an electronic recruitment system and lifted the Community's standing recruitment moratorium at a Dedicated Meeting in Mombasa, 18-21 August, directing the Secretariat to advertise 69 priority positions across every partner state from FY 2026/2027.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

A Rwandan analyst argued on 1 August that East Africa has built an AI application economy and mistaken it for an AI industry, since most local startups do not own the intelligence in their own products — engineering, demand and citizens' data generate value that accrues elsewhere — and named financing regional GPU infrastructure as the real agenda, disclosing that his own company sells into that answer.

Instruments and harmonisation

AI

COMESA consulted in Kigali on 6 August on two regional instruments it is drafting in parallel, an AI strategy and a digital-inclusion strategy, after similar engagements in Kenya and Zambia; neither has a published date, drafter or adoption route, and Rwanda's own AI-policy progress was cited at the same consultation as a case COMESA is drawing on for its regional framework.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

Africa's peering forum, AfPIF, opened in Kigali on 13 August with landlocked markets at the centre of its 2026 edition, framed around inland East and Central African markets with no direct submarine-cable landing access. Paratus marked its first anniversary in Rwanda at the same event on 18 August, showcasing the roughly 2,000km Goma–Mombasa fibre corridor it launched in February, which the company says now connects into a 16-country network alongside its Starlink-powered services.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Under the EU-EAC DEEP programme, GIZ tendered an e-commerce business-development consultancy on 7 August, following a Tanzania/Uganda/Kenya-facing DPI consulting tender on 5 August and a DPI technical-assistance tender on 31 July; each is a procurement notice rather than a project, so the programme remains at the pipeline-preparation stage across digital ID, data exchange, payments and e-government, with no budget, duration or award stated for any of the three.

National statistics

Two statistical-harmonisation strands moved in parallel: IGAD convened a capacity-building programme to strengthen regional statistical systems through SDMX, reported 6 August, following the EAC Secretariat's own technical session at the end of July to harmonise SDMX data-structure definitions for consumer-price and merchandise-trade statistics. Separately, EACO published its first regulator-submitted communications-sector statistics report on 3 August, covering all seven member states: 334.69 million active mobile subscriptions in 2025 and mobile-money value up 19.6% across the five reporting countries, with the Democratic Republic of Congo and South Sudan reporting no transaction values at all and every mobile-money figure given in US dollars despite EACO's own stated local-currency methodology, with no conversion basis disclosed.

Use of satellite data

Uganda, Kenya, Rwanda and South Sudan opened a dedicated "East African Development Bank-NCIP" account at Standard Chartered Bank Uganda on 24 August to fund a feasibility study for a jointly owned regional communications satellite, with partner states given until 30 September to deposit their contributions. Neither the study's cost nor each country's share is disclosed, so whether the deadline is demanding or trivial cannot be said — but the named account itself makes non-payment dated and visible in a way a communiqué would not.

Capacity and inclusion

Training and skills

The EAC's AI-in-education workstream reached its most concrete milestone yet: [UNESCO, GIZ and the Inter-University Council for East Africa convened a pre-conference workshop in Nairobi on 25 August](#), ahead of the [2nd EAC Regional Education Conference \(25-28 August, nearly 200 presentations across nine sub-themes\)](#). The conference's [communique](#) sets the EAC Secretariat to lead monitoring through an accountability framework of measurable regional and country-owned targets to 2028, with peer review through existing EAC mechanisms and a 3rd conference hosted by Uganda in 2028 — routed through a donor-convened alliance and a university council rather than through the Secretariat's own organs.

Finance

New investments

The African Development Bank is funding a regional entrepreneurship and innovation project of about US\$3.26 million across Sudan, South Sudan and Djibouti through its transition support mechanism with IGAD, Sudan's national component launching on 19 August and running on the ground through the [University of Khartoum's entrepreneurship incubator centre](#). No allocation between the three countries, disbursement schedule or enrolment target is published.

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